equipped for the task at hand. After much debate, it was agreed upon that as a last resort, if our own physical security was at stake, that detachment and that detachment alone, could open fire in self-defence.

By the evening of the 30th, we were in a strong position both on the North and South Bank as well as the Kailash Range. On the North Bank, we had about a Brigade-plus strength (1/1 GR, 5/4 GR, 2 SIKH LI and 9 SF) as also 17 KUMAON and 16 PUNJAB from the local formation; on the South Bank almost two Brigades-worth of troops (2 DOGRA, 11 SIKH LI, 6 SIKH, 2 LADAKH SCOUTS, 4 LADAKH SCOUTS and 7 VIKAS). On the Kailash Ranges further South, was another Brigade (6 GRENADIERS, 29 PUNJAB, 13 MAHAR). Elements of Mech Forces (18 GUARDS, 53 Armoured Regt) had also been staged forward and were at the base of these Ridges, including at Tara Post. All these units and formations were those of 6 Mtn Division and 39 Mtn Division, that had been painstakingly inducted into the sector over the previous two months, as also the local units and formations. They had had time to acclimatize as well as carry out training in the rear areas in this high-altitude region. They were fully equipped with all the clothing and equipment required for carrying out their tasks. And when the time came, all of them performed splendidly. In the words of Lt Gen HS Panag, 'Our deception—both at the strategic and tactical level—was perfect to a fault as was the tactical movement of our troops.'[3] What was even more creditable, in my view, is that we had been able to achieve this kind of surprise despite the heightened state of alertness. We definitely caught the PLA with their pants down.

The PLA reaction was not long in coming. On the 30th evening itself, they moved forward some troops in the area of the Kailash Range, stopping about 500 m short of our locations

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